One Case, Two Timelines

The same real-world request, walked through today's email-and-spreadsheet process and through the agent-built Workbench — written for anyone, no banking background required.

First, what is this "FCRM" thing, and why does a bank need it? Banks are legally required to make sure they aren't accidentally helping criminals move money, evade sanctions, or fund illegal activity. So any time a bank wants to try something new — sell a new product, work with a new type of customer, open in a new country — a specialized team has to stop and ask: *could this new thing make it easier for bad actors to abuse us, and are we set up to handle it responsibly?* That team is called Financial Crimes Risk Management, or FCRM. Think of them as the bank's safety inspectors for money crime: nothing new launches until they've signed off.

The scenario: banking cannabis dispensaries

Say the bank's Commercial Banking team wants to start opening business accounts for licensed cannabis dispensaries in Colorado and Michigan, where selling cannabis is legal under state law. Here's the catch: cannabis is still illegal under *federal* law, and this bank is federally regulated. Dispensaries also tend to handle unusually large amounts of cash, because many card companies won't work with them — and cash-heavy businesses are exactly the kind criminals like to use to hide illegally-earned money. So before Commercial Banking can say yes to a single dispensary customer, FCRM has to work out: is this legal for us, how risky is it, and if we do it, under what conditions? The decision can land on four outcomes — approved, rejected, deferred, or approved with conditions. This walkthrough follows the case to the outcome it actually reaches:

APPROVED · WITH CONDITIONS



Both bars are drawn on the same day scale. The two flowcharts below show why the gap is this large.

Same request, two very different paths

Each box is one real step in the process. The tag on each step names how it actually gets done today, and which Workbench module does it after.

BEFORE — Email, Word & SharePoint

One analyst, whatever they remember, start to finish

1

DAY 0

Commercial Banking emails the FCRM inbox asking to approve banking for cannabis dispensaries, with a one-page write-up attached.

EMAIL + WORD DOC

2

DAYS 1–3

The request sits in a shared inbox until an analyst has time to pick it up.

SHARED INBOX

3

DAYS 3–5

The analyst searches for the bank's cannabis-banking policy and finds three different versions in SharePoint, with no clear current one.

SHAREPOINT

4

DAYS 5–8

The analyst emails colleagues asking if anyone remembers how a similar case was handled before, and waits for replies.

EMAIL

5

DAYS 8–11

The analyst manually looks up every dispensary owner's name, one at a time, against watch lists and news reports.

MANUAL LOOKUPS

6

DAYS 11–15

The analyst writes a risk opinion in Word based on her own judgment, and emails back and forth with Commercial Banking for missing details.

WORD DOC

7

DAYS 15–19

The write-up is emailed to the Risk Committee, who discuss it at their next scheduled meeting and vote informally.

Misses this month's meeting? Add ~20 more days.

8

~DAY 20

The decision is emailed back to Commercial Banking.

Months later, an examiner asks why this was approved.
Someone digs back through old emails, Word drafts and meeting notes to reconstruct the reasoning.

SLOW. OFTEN INCOMPLETE.

AFTER — The Risk Assessment Workbench

Same rigor, applied by agents, checked by people

1

DAY 0 · MINUTES

Commercial Banking submits the request in the Workbench: what's changing, where, and who's affected.

M1 · INTAKE

2

DAY 0 · WITHIN THE HOUR

The system reads the attached documents, finds the current cannabis-banking policy, and screens every named owner against watch lists — all at once.

M2 · M3 · M4, IN PARALLEL

3

DAY 0 · SAME DAY

The system scores the risk with the bank's official scorecard — the same one every time — and writes a full draft assessment with everything cited.

M5 · M6

4

DAY 0–1

An FCRM analyst reviews the ready-made draft — checking and editing it rather than building it from scratch — and finalizes it.

GATE 1 · HUMAN DECISION REQUIRED

5

DAY 1–2

The Risk Committee reviews the same complete record and records its decision: Approved, with conditions.

GATE 2 · HUMAN DECISION REQUIRED

6

DAY 2

Commercial Banking is notified automatically; the case is closed and permanently archived.